

The classification conundrum



Para athletes talk about their **varying experiences** with classification, the defining foundation of para sports where the playing field is levelled.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Lavanya Lakshmi Narayanan
lavanya.ln@thehindu.co.in

Para badminton player Sukant Kadam (**left**), who will feature in his maiden Paralympics in Paris, chuckles when asked about his first classification experience. "There's a funny story here. I was domestically classified as SL3 and played and perfected those rules. In 2014, when I went to England for my first international tournament, the classifiers there suddenly placed me in the SL4 bracket instead. That was a shock for me," Kadam told *Sportstar* in the run-up to the Paris 2024 Games.

SL3 and SL4 are competing classes in para badminton for athletes with lower limb impairments. SL3 is for those with more severe levels of disability, requiring athletes to play on a half-width court. Kadam suffered a severe knee injury as a child, and multiple surgeries left him with impaired movement.

"SL4 meant I had to learn to play full court. There were such accomplished athletes already in this bracket, and I found